LITTLE BLUE BOOK NO. 50
Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

Common Sense

Thomas Paine

HALDEMAN-JULIUS COMPANY
GIRARD, KANSAS

J. J. Martin Papers
Bancroft Library

TEN CENT POCKET SERIES NO. 50
Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

Common Sense

Thomas Paine

HALDEMAN-JULIUS COMPANY
GIRARD, KANSAS

EXPLANATORY NOTICE.*

The North American Republic consists of twenty-four regularly organized States, and an immense extent of territory not yet formed into States, which, with the exception of some mountain ridges, is wholly susceptible of cultivation. It contains upwards of two millions of square miles, and is therefore thirteen times as large as France, twenty-three times as large as England, and would, were it peopled as densely as these countries, contain FOUR HUNDRED MILLIONS OF PEOPLE. It is watered on its eastern, western, and part of its southern sides by the ocean, and on part of its northern frontier by immense lakes. It is intersected in

---

*This clear and concise statement of the origin of the American war for independence is from an edition of Common Sense published in 1848 by J. Watson, 3 Queen's Head Passage, Paternoster Row, London. At that time the English publishers were permitted to print Paine's political writings unmutilated, as they now appear, without molestation by the government: but the early editions of both Common Sense and the Rights of Man were issued in a very imperfect form to avoid prosecution; all adverse criticism of the king or parliament, of tyrants and tyranny, being sternly suppressed. The vacant lines in the pages of the edition of Common Sense published by J. Almon, opposite Burlington-house in Piccadilly, 1776. and the many suppressed passages in the Rights of Man published by H. D. Symonds, Paternoster-Row, 1792, of J. S. Jordon, 166 Fleet-street, 1791, and many others, are all mute yet eloquent witnesses of the injustice and tyranny exercised by the British government in the 18th century.—Am. Pub.

all directions by magnificent rivers, and has more facilities for water conveyance than any other continental country; it abounds in mines and minerals, and produces everything necessary for the sustenance and enjoyment of mankind.

The population of the United States has been several times doubled in periods of less than twenty-five years, it now contains upwards of twelve millions of people, and bids fair at no very distant period to be more populous and powerful than any nation ever was.

Such is the present state, and such the prospects of a nation originally settled by men who either fled from religious intolerance and persecution to seek peace in the wilderness—by men whose notions of liberty were too high to permit them to endure the tyranny they were subjected to at home,—or by men who sought their fortunes as commercial speculators or cultivators of the land. From Britons thus circumstanced has sprung a people who have increased in number, wealth, and intelligence with a rapidity of which history furnishes no parallel.

From the time that the commerce of the North American Colonies became worth the notice of the British Government, it was put under the most pernicious and absurd restraints, for the supposed advantage of the mother country, and laws were occasionally passed here to regulate their internal affairs.

In the war which preceded the peace of 1762. the Colonists took a very decided part, and greatly contributed to the conquests made from

the French. Canada, which had been taken from that people, was retained by the British, and Florida was ceded to us by Spain. Thus secured from attack by foreign neighbors, Great Britain and her Colonies were more than ever attached to each other. The Americans were proud of the land of their ancestors and gloried in their descent from Englishmen. This state of harmony was, however, of short duration. The unexampled expenses of war required additional taxes to a large amount, and the difficulty this occasioned led the government in 1764 seriously to contemplate the levying of taxes in the colonies. This was objected to by the colonists, unless they were permitted to send representatives to the British Parliament; to this the government would not consent, and a dispute commenced which ended in the separation of the two countries.

Some at least if not all the colonies contended that they possessed every legislative power not surrendered by compact: whilst in Britain it was contended on the part of the government that "Parliament possessed the power of binding them in all cases whatever."

The dispute became serious, but so contemptible was the power of the colonists considered in the eyes of the English government that in a debate in the House of Commons General Grant, who should have known better, declared that "with five regiments of infantry he would undertake to traverse the whole country and drive the inhabitants from one end of it to the other." This contempt was not only entertained by the government and its adher-

ents, but by the people, who were eager to compel their American brethren to submission by force of arms, against which the voice of a few wise men was of no avail. The colonists continuing to refuse the unconditional submission demanded, recourse was had to arms, and on the night of the 18th of April, 1775, they were attacked by the king's troops at Lexington, and here the first American blood was spilt by their English brethren. The Americans repelled the aggression, appointed GEORGE WASHINGTON Commander-in-chief, and a desultory civil war desolated the colonies. The people were undecided in opinion, some were for submission, and others who deprecated the conduct of government, and publicly declared their detestation, disapproved of resistance as useless, and few were disposed to risk their lives and property in a contest of which none appeared able to foretell the consequences. The doctrine of independence was a novelty hitherto but slightly advocated by its friends, and they, from the want of numbers and the timidity always attendant on newly-started notions, were looked upon as rash and dangerous, or teacherous and designing men, more deserving of suspicion and censure than of applause and imitation.

It was in this crisis, this interval between fear and principle, that Thomas Paine, then unknown as a public character, published the pamphlet Common Sense.* Taking a broader

*"At the close of the year 1775," says Calvin Blanchard in his Life of Paine, "when the American Revolution had progressed as far as the